

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Mayor won't veto budget

Johnson concedes in historic struggle that reached brink of a government shutdown

By Alice Yin and Jake Sheridan
Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson announced Tuesday he will not veto the 2026 budget passed by aldermen, conceding a historic struggle that reached the brink of a government shutdown and burned his goodwill with the City Council.

Speaking outside the mayor's office on the fifth floor of City Hall, Johnson confirmed he will not veto the \$16.6 billion counterproposal to his spending plan for next year, despite his ongoing

objections to his council rivals' package, which nixes his corporate head tax. His decision comes days before the end-of-year deadline to either finalize a budget or imperil vital city services as well as tens of thousands of paychecks.

"I will not add the risk and speculation of a government shutdown to the profound worries Chicagoans face," Johnson said, before expressing optimism about his stalled progressive agenda. "Aren't you glad that we have many more budgets to pass?"

Turn to Budget, Page 7



Mayor Brandon Johnson signs an executive order in his ceremonial office at City Hall on Dec. 23, 2025, ahead of a news conference about the city's 2026 budget. **DOMINIC DI PALERMO/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

High court blocks troop deployment to Illinois

Win for Pritzker, other Dem governors in battle with Trump over Guard

By Jason Meisner, Jeremy Gornier and Madeline Buckley
Chicago Tribune

The U.S. Supreme Court on Tuesday denied a request from President Donald Trump's administration to allow the Republican president to deploy National Guard troops to Illinois streets while a court battle over a restraining order plays out.

The conservative-majority court's order represents a significant political victory for Gov. JB Pritzker and other Democratic governors in their escalating battle with Trump over his authority to go against their wishes and use federalized troops on U.S. soil to assist immigration enforcement personnel carrying out the president's mass deportation efforts in Chicago and other American cities.

While considering a Trump motion to stay a lower court's order blocking the deployment, the Supreme Court asked the administration and the state of Illinois to submit supplemental briefs regarding a provision in federal law that Trump says allows him to dispatch National Guard troops in cases where there is an invasion, a rebellion or a time when the president "is unable with the regular forces to execute the laws of the United States."

"At this preliminary stage, the Government has failed to identify a source of authority that would allow the military to execute the laws in Illinois," the order Tuesday said. "Thus, at least in this posture, the Government has not carried its burden to show that (the law) permits the President to federalize the Guard in the exercise of inherent authority to protect federal personnel and property in Illinois."

The key issue the high court sought briefings on was whether the term "regular forces" means "the regular forces of the United States military," and if so, how that fits into existing law involving the president's power to order up the National Guard.

In the order Tuesday, the justices did not find merit to the Trump administration's argument that "regular forces" refers to civilian law enforcement such as immigration agents.

Turn to Court, Page 2



A CTA Red Line train travels through the median of the Dan Ryan Expressway south of downtown on Dec. 15. **BRIAN CASSELLA/TRIBUNE PHOTOS**

READY, SET, SOON?

Trump administration froze grant funding in October, threatening Red Line extension

By Talia Soglin
Chicago Tribune

Banners posted at the Chicago Transit Authority's 95th Street station promise: "Ready, set, soon! The Red Line Extension is coming."

Anticipation for the rail project has been building since January when, just 10 days before President Donald Trump took office, the CTA locked down almost \$2 billion in federal grant dollars to help extend the Red Line from 95th Street to 130th Street. The CTA's president at the time, Dorval Carter, said the long-promised undertaking to bring CTA rail access to the Far South Side would "undo nearly 60 years of racial inequity in transit."

But in October, the Trump administration froze the Red Line grant dollars, citing the transit agency's diversity require-



Mariah Williams enters the CTA 95th Street station on Dec. 15 after commuting by bus to reach the Red Line terminus and head to her job.

ments for contractors.

Since then, the CTA has not been able to receive federal reimbursements for work on the project, which has also been criticized for its hefty \$5.75 billion

price tag.

The agency says it's still on track to officially break ground next year and open the extension — and four brand-new train stations — in 2030. And over the

last few months, workers have continued early site preparation on the Far South Side, testing soil and demolishing properties to make way for new train stations and track.

The CTA has also continued to pay for that work: As recently as Dec. 5, records show, it sent contractor Walsh-VINCI \$23.5 million in one of more than a dozen payments it's made since fall 2024. So far, the CTA has paid Walsh-VINCI — which directed all questions to the CTA — about \$415 million out of a \$2.9 billion contract.

But experts say the longer the freeze goes on, the more challenging it will be to keep the Red Line project chugging along.

The CTA can continue making payments on the project during the funding pause, but it can't get reimbursed by the federal

Turn to Red Line, Page 4

DOGE's work disrupted much but saved little

Musk failed to cut federal spending by \$1T before October

By Emily Badger, David A. Fahrenthold, Alicia Parlapiano and Margot Sanger-Katz
The New York Times

WASHINGTON — Elon Musk's Department of Government Efficiency said it made more than 29,000 cuts to the federal government — slashing

billion-dollar contracts, canceling thousands of grants and pushing out civil servants.

But the group did not do what Musk said it would: reduce federal spending by \$1 trillion before October. On DOGE's watch, federal spending did not go down at all. It went up.

How is that possible?

One big reason, according to a New York Times analysis: Many of the largest savings that DOGE claimed turned out to be wrong. And while the group did make thousands of smaller cuts, jolting

foreign aid recipients, American small businesses and local service providers, those amounted to little in the scale of the federal budget.

In DOGE's published list of canceled contracts and grants, the 13 largest were all incorrect.

At the top were two Defense Department contracts, one for information technology, one for aircraft maintenance. Musk's group listed them as "terminations" and said their demise had saved taxpayers \$7.9 billion. That was not true.

The contracts are still alive and well, and those savings were an accounting mirage.

Together, those two false entries were bigger than 25,000 of DOGE's other claims combined.

Of the 40 biggest claims on DOGE's list, the Times found only 12 that appeared accurate — reflecting real reductions in what the government had committed to spend.

The Times' analysis helps

Turn to DOGE, Page 7

INSIDE



EILEEN T. MESLAR/TRIBUNE

Is Johnson NFL's coach of the year?

With the Bears playoff-bound, does that make Ben Johnson the league's top coach? That and other pressing questions ahead of Week 17. Plus, three Bears make the Pro Bowl roster. **Chicago Sports**

EPSTEIN FILES: The Justice Department releases more files, including some that mention President Trump. **Nation & World**

TODAY'S WEATHER

High **45**
Low **38**



Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 14

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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